Driving Sustainable AI Adoption: A Framework for Preventing Burnout Amid Growing AI Strain

Abstract

Artificial intelligence has catalyzed widespread interest, enthusiasm, and anxiety among the public. While its rapid adoption within organizations has significantly raised expectations for both the speed and quality of work, this profound shift in how work is performed has introduced new forms of strain as individuals and teams adapt to AI-accelerated workflows. An employee who relies on AI tools may experience efficiency gains, but may also experience increasing pressure to work faster, review more outputs, learn new skills, and remain constantly available. Although moderate strain can be productive and support learning and growth, prolonged or poorly managed strain can grow into burnout and impede broad adoption of AI into organizational workflows. This paper identifies seven empirically backed, emerging strains associated with AI-accelerated work and offers practical, actionable strategies for leaders to ensure that AI-related strain remains manageable and empowering.

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1. What Is AI-Induced Burnout, and Why Does It Matter?

AI-induced burnout (sometimes called **"AI fatigue"** or **AI-related technostress**) is a modern variant of occupational burnout that arises from the intensive demands of adopting and working with artificial intelligence tools. We identify it as a pattern of chronic work-related exhaustion, disengagement, and reduced sense of efficacy that emerges not simply from using AI,[1] but from the *way AI reshapes job demands, pace, and expectations at work*. It is best understood as an extension of established occupational burnout frameworks, activated by AI-specific stressors such as accelerated work cycles, continuous learning demands, intensified cognitive load,[2] and blurred boundaries between work and nonwork time.

Importantly, this framing does not claim that AI creates burnout as a wholly new phenomenon; rather, AI can shift the balance between demands and resources, increasing the risk that existing burnout mechanisms are triggered or amplified if organisational guardrails do not keep pace. Burnout matters because decades of occupational research consistently link it to lower sustained productivity, higher absenteeism and sickness, and increased turnover intentions, making it both a human and organisational risk.[3]

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[1] Maslach, C., & Jackson, S. E. (1981). *The measurement of experienced burnout*. Journal of Occupational Behavior, 2(2), 99–113. https://doi.org/10.1002/job.4030020205
Maslach, C., & Leiter, M. P. (2016). *Understanding the burnout experience: Recent research and its implications*. World Psychiatry, 15(2), 103–111. https://doi.org/10.1002/wps.20311
World Health Organization (2019). *Burn-out in the ICD-11*. https://www.who.int/news/item/28-05-2019-burn-out-an-occupational-phenomenon-international-classification-of-diseases
Maslach, C., Leiter, M. P. (2016). *Understanding the burnout experience: Recent research and its implications*. World Psychiatry, 15(2), 103–111.
World Health Organization (2019). *Burn-out in the ICD-11*.
[2] Ranganathan, A., & Ye, X. M. (2026). *AI Doesn't Reduce Work — It Intensifies It*. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/2026/02/ai-doesnt-reduce-work-it-intensifies-it
[3] Ali, S. A., Alaghbari, M. A., & Al Astal, A. Y. (2024). *Burnout and its impact on employee performance: A comprehensive systematic review*. Springer.
Salyers et al. (2017). The relationship between professional burnout and quality and safety in healthcare: A meta-analysis. Journal of General Internal Medicine.
Tarro et al. (2020). *Effectiveness of workplace interventions for improving absenteeism, productivity, and work ability: A meta-analysis*. IJERPH.
Wright, T. A., & Cropanzano, R. (1998). *Emotional exhaustion as a predictor of job performance and voluntary turnover*. Journal of Applied Psychology.

Day in the life – how AI adoption can exacerbate burnout

It is 9:15 a.m., and a software engineer logs in to start the day. Yesterday, they finished setting up GitHub Copilot. It is impressive: drafting code faster, filling in boilerplate, helping them move through task X more smoothly than before. By mid-morning, they are running Copilot-assisted workflows while joining a company-wide presentation on Claude Code in parallel. During the session, they are told that Claude Code is significantly more powerful and that teams should begin migrating their workflows. After the presentation, they bookmark the setup guide - something to do later.

Meanwhile, expectations have not slowed. Task X still needs to be delivered, but now task Y has been added, because "with AI, this should be quicker." Before lunch, they start experimenting with Claude Code alongside Copilot, comparing outputs, validating results, and deciding which tool to trust. Each switch feels small, even energizing. There is no single moment of overload - just fewer pauses, more decisions, and a growing sense that keeping up requires constant attention.

By the end of the day, more has been produced. But it is harder to say whether the day felt lighter - or simply faster.

This issue is especially salient for heavy and highly skilled AI users, the very population organisations often rely on to lead AI adoption. Recent large-scale survey evidence suggests a paradox: while these workers report higher AI proficiency and usage, they also report significantly higher burnout risk and weaker feelings of connection to their organisation. For example, the 2025 Upwork Research Institute survey of 2,500 global workers found that the highest-performing AI users — those in the top quartile for productivity gains — reported an 88% burnout rate and were twice as likely to consider quitting, while 62% felt disconnected from their organisation's broader AI strategy.[4] This pattern underscores a critical design implication: successful AI adoption cannot be reduced to a simple "more usage is better" logic. Instead, organisations must treat AI as a socio-technical system, deliberately pairing capability gains with human-centered design principles, norms, and protections. Just as high-performance systems require constraints to function safely, AI-enabled work requires intentional guardrails to ensure that efficiency gains do not translate into unsustainable human cost. A useful analogy is modern transport: cars can travel at high speed precisely because they are equipped with brakes. Without brakes, vehicles would not go faster or farther; they would crash

[4] Upwork Research Institute (2025). *From Tools to Teammates: Navigating the New Human–AI Relationship.*

more often and fail to achieve their purpose. In the same way, AI-enabled work requires constraints and safeguards to ensure that increased capability translates into sustainable performance rather than breakdown.

In addition, as AI tools and models continue to evolve, organizations and workforces must continuously evaluate how they can appropriately rely on AI to help their workstreams, either through assistance, partnering or delegation. Research shows that there are three major barriers that impact appropriate reliance: flawed mental models of what AI can do, reliance of flawed heuristics (e.g. fluency bias) and information overload from verbose AI output. For example, anthropomorphizing AI or dismissing entirely both lead to mis-calibrated reliance. Vasconcelos et al. (2023) showed that fluent and confident sounding AI outputs cause users to accept incorrect information and cognitive load from lengthy, detailed AI outputs can paradoxically make it harder for users to critically evaluate content, resulting in default acceptance. All of these downsides necessitate integration of the human worker in workflows as reviewers, evaluators and often, final decision makers, but the shift of role may also be less enjoyable leading to further disengagement and burnout.

This paper proceeds in three parts. First, we define AI-induced burnout and distinguish it from related constructs - strain, technostress, and AI fatigue - before mapping the seven principal AI-related stressors that drive it. Second, we propose a measurement framework that pairs traditional survey instruments with behavioural signals from tools such as Microsoft Viva Insights, enabling early detection of strain before it crystallises into burnout. Third, we outline practical organisational strategies for rebalancing demands and resources in AI-enabled work. Throughout, our aim is to give leaders a conceptually grounded and operationally actionable understanding of AI-induced burnout: one that treats productivity and wellbeing not as trade-offs, but as jointly achievable goals.

The Strain–Burnout Relationship: A Critical Distinction

Strain is the acute, fluctuating response to stressors—anxiety, fatigue, cognitive depletion, somatic complaints. It operates on a day-to-day or even hour-to-hour timescale.[5] Strain is what employees experience when AI-related demands first hit.

[5] Kahn, R. L., & Byosiere, P. (1992). *Stress in organizations*. In M. D. Dunnette & L. M. Hough (Eds.), *Handbook of industrial and organizational psychology* (Vol. 3, 2nd ed., pp. 571–650). Consulting Psychologists Press.

Burnout is the chronic syndrome (exhaustion, cynicism, reduced efficacy) that develops when strain accumulates unresolved over weeks and months[6].

The National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (NIOSH) makes this explicit: burnout is "a very serious strain state." [7] The relationship is not strain versus burnout: it is strain becoming burnout along a temporal continuum. Selye's General Adaptation Syndrome maps the pathway: alarm (acute arousal) → resistance (ongoing coping) → exhaustion (resource depletion = burnout). Ranganathan and Ye documented this transition taking approximately 8 months in AI adoption contexts. [8]

STRESSORS	STRAIN	→	BURNOUT
External Demands	*Acute Response*	*If unresolved...*	*Chronic Syndrome*
Workload, time pressure, AI adoption, job insecurity, role ambiguity	Anxiety, fatigue, and cognitive depletion. Fluctuates day-to-day.	COR resource loss spirals; Selye's exhaustion stage; ~8 months (Ranganathan & Ye, 2026)	Exhaustion, cynicism, reduced efficacy. Entrenched over weeks/months.

Figure: The Stressor → Strain → Burnout Continuum. Based on Selye (1936), Kahn & Byosiere (1992), Maslach et al. (2001), NIOSH (2024), Ranganathan & Ye (2026).

This distinction matters for measurement: strain can be detected through near-real-time behavioural signals, while burnout requires periodic survey assessment. Detecting strain early, before it crystallizes into burnout, gives organizations a window to intervene.

In this white paper, burnout is the primary outcome of concern. It is the chronic endpoint that carries the greatest human and organisational cost. Strain serves as the key mediating variable, sitting between AI-related stressors and burnout on the causal pathway. Crucially, it is also the point at which intervention remains tractable. Detecting and addressing strain early, before it crystallises into burnout, is the central logic underlying both our measurement framework and our mitigation strategies

[6] Maslach, C., Schaufeli, W. B., & Leiter, M. P. (2001). *Job burnout*. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 52(1), 397–422. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.psych.52.1.397

[7] National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (NIOSH). (2024). *Occupational burnout*. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.

[8] Ranganathan, A., & Ye, X. M. (2026). *AI doesn't reduce work — it intensifies it*. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/2026/02/ai-doesnt-reduce-work-it-intensifies-it

Defining Burnout in the AI Era

Maslach's framework

The classic definition of burnout comes from psychologist Christina Maslach, who identified burnout as a three-dimensional syndrome of (i) emotional exhaustion, (ii) cynicism (depersonalization), and (iii) reduced sense of professional efficacy due to chronic workplace stress. [9] In simpler terms, burnout means feeling drained, becoming detached or negative towards work and people, and feeling like you're not effective anymore.

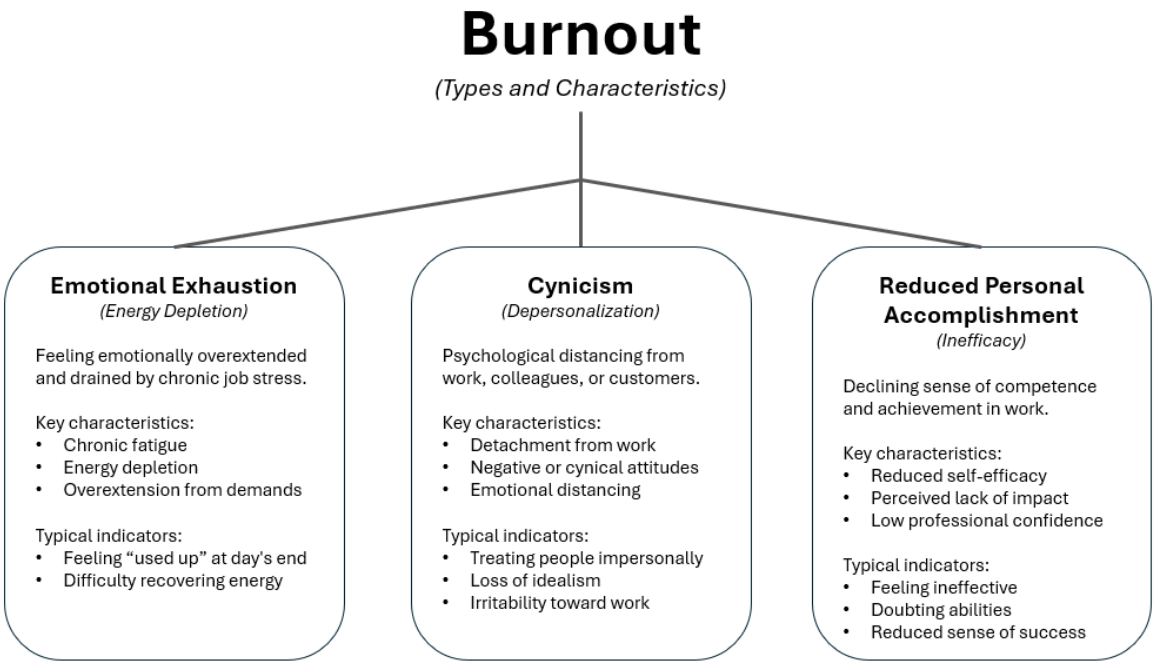

Figure 1: Occupational burnout types and characteristics

Exhaustion (Physical & Emotional Fatigue)

The core of burnout is exhaustion – feeling worn out, depleted, and unable to "recharge" due to continuous stress. AI can contribute to exhaustion by accelerating the pace of work and extending working hours (for example, AI-enabled "always-on" connectivity can erode boundaries between work and rest, as discussed below) [10].

Cynicism (Depersonalization/Detachment)

Burned-out employees often develop a cynical or distant attitude towards their job and colleagues. In an AI-driven workplace, this might manifest as resentment towards constant technological change or feeling alienated by the replacement of

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[9] Maslach, C., & Jackson, S. E. (1981). *The measurement of experienced burnout*. Journal of Occupational Behavior, 2(2), 99–113. https://doi.org/10.1002/job.4030020205

[10] Derks, D., van Mierlo, H., & Schmitz, E. B. (2014). A diary study on work-related smartphone use, psychological detachment and exhaustion: Examining the role of the perceived segmentation norm. *Journal of Occupational Health Psychology*, 19(1), 74–84. https://doi.org/10.1037/a0035076

human interaction with machines. For instance, if employees increasingly "talk" to AI systems instead of coworkers, they may feel less sense of belonging and trust, becoming disconnected or alienated from their team.[11]

Reduced Efficacy (Lack of Accomplishment)

Burnout erodes people's belief that they are effective in their role. AI can affect this in two ways. On one hand, employees overwhelmed by rapid change might feel less competent (struggling to keep up with new tools, fearing *"Am I being outperformed by the AI?"*). On the other hand, over-reliance on AI can diminish the sense of personal achievement – if the AI does "all the easy work," employees may be left questioning their own value, feeling their role has been diminished or deskilled. [12] Research in 2025 found that while AI assistance boosted short-term productivity, it also led to an 11% decrease in intrinsic motivation and a 20% increase in boredom once people returned to solo work.[13] In other words, work became less meaningful when AI took over the more straightforward tasks, leaving humans with only high-level or supervisory tasks and a feeling of eroded accomplishment.

In the age of AI, these burnout dimensions can be activated by a distinct set of "AI-shaped" job demands. Importantly, the claim is not that AI creates burnout from scratch, but that it can shift the balance of demands and resources: it lowers the effort needed to produce drafts, analyses, and responses, which can unintentionally create higher volumes of content, expand scope, compress cycles, and increase cognitive demands, especially when norms and guardrails don't keep pace. This aligns with the broader goal of our work: distinguishing productive augmentation from work intensification under specific conditions.

Contributors to AI-Induced Burnout

We conducted both a literature review and a thematic analysis of posts on the social network Reddit. The goal of the two-pronged approach was to correlate both academic viewpoints with public sentiment related to feeling "exhausted" or strained by "AI." While our initial thematic analysis found an overwhelming majority of the posts from September 2025 to early March 2026 focused on the frustration and

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[11] ZDNet (2024). Heavy AI use at work has a surprising relationship to burnout, new study finds. ZDNet. https://www.zdnet.com/article/heavy-ai-use-at-work-has-a-surprising-relationship-to-burnout-new-study-finds/

[12] Deci, E. L., & Ryan, R. M. (2000). The "what" and "why" of goal pursuits: Human needs and the self-determination of behavior. *Psychological Inquiry*, 11(4), 227–268. https://doi.org/10.1207/S15327965PLI1104_01

[13] Wu, S., Liu, Y., Ruan, M., Chen, S., & Xie, X. Y. (2025). Human-generative AI collaboration enhances task performance but undermines human's intrinsic motivation. *Scientific Reports, 15*(1), 15105. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-025-98385-2. Companion HBR article: Liu, Y., Wu, S., Ruan, M., Chen, S., & Xie, X. Y. (2025, May). Research: Gen AI makes people more productive — and less motivated. *Harvard Business Review.* https://hbr.org/2025/05/research-gen-ai-makes-people-more-productive-and-less-motivated

feelings of being inundated with AI news in the media, on social networks, and from organizational leadership, we narrowed our analysis to the posts related to AI tool use, clustering them based on common concerns, experiences, or feelings and labeling those clusters as themes. We then aligned these themes with the even identified AI strains found in academic literature. These strains we have identified can either contribute, or moderate burnout signal in an AI user.

1. Fragmented focus and information overload (task switching and multitasking intensity)

This pathway captures how AI tools can multiply digital interruptions and decision points, from approval prompts to autogenerated recommendations and summaries. Rather than simplifying the stream of information, AI can increase the volume of content entering workflows and the number of "approve/edit/verify" decisions workers must make.

In many roles, work begins to look less like sustained deep focus on a single problem and more like managing multiple agents or chat windows. In writing-heavy roles, faster drafting can paradoxically produce more drafts and more stakeholder iterations, increasing context switching rather than reducing it. People on Reddit reported managing several ongoing tasks at once:

> *"As the grind gets compressed, more of the cognitive load shifts onto you.* ***Instead of working through one hard problem end to end, you're now supervising several partially solved ones at once,*** *as you say: reviewing AI output, steering prompts, sanity-checking logic, and keeping multiple approaches in your head. That's why the work can feel more mentally tiring even though it's technically easier."*

[14]

> *"****AI speeds up execution, but shifts the load to supervision, review, and context switching****. You type less, but think more. Before: tired hands. Now: tired brain. What usually helps: • Limit parallel tasks (one problem with AI at a time) • Externalize thinking (write decisions/prompts down) • Accept that faster output ≠ lower cognitive load"*

[8]

[14] "AI is making me faster, but also more mentally tired." www.reddit.com/r/ArtificialIntelligence/comments/1q80j0m/ai_is_making_me_faster_but_also_more_mentally_tired/ 9 Jan 2026

> *"I've been using AI daily for a while now and the speed boost is real, there's no denying it. With things like [tools] speeding up frontend and UI work, I can move through tasks way faster than before. But I notice the work feels more exhausting even though it's technically easier,* ***I'm jumping between more things at once,*** *reviewing AI generated code, adjusting prompts, sanity checking logic and keeping track of multiple approaches in my head at the same time.* ***Instead of struggling with one hard problem, I'm now managing five half-solved ones in parallel****. The code often works, but staying focused, confident, and mentally present takes more energy than it used to."*

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2. Pressure to continuously learn new AI tools & workflows (Learning time, technostress)

Even before generative AI, digital technologies have been known to create *techno-overload* (too much work), *techno-invasion* (constant connectivity), *techno-complexity* (learning challenges), and *techno-uncertainty* (continuous changes), all of which can fuel stress and burnout. Generative AI has simply dialed these factors up to new levels – e.g., intensifying *workload* (through always-on expectations), adding complexity (new tools), and so on.

Many workers experience AI as a permanent learning curve layered on top of existing responsibilities, with little protected time to adapt. Posts in this theme commonly discuss the pace of AI and feeling either unprepared or unable to keep up with learning all the new tools. For example, one person wrote:

> *"****The pace in AI has increased so much that I sometimes feel like I'm already behind.*** *I keep thinking 'I should try this too' or 'maybe that model is better' and the constant indecision is starting to feel more exhausting than exciting. It's impossible to test everything, but you also don't want to miss out on something important. I honestly can't keep up with the tempo. How are you managing this?"*

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Similarly, there is a feeling that leaders push new tools to teams with the goal of increasing productivity, causing the teams to scramble to onboard and learn the new tools very quickly, only to be given another new tool shortly thereafter. With the title of "*AI is draining my passion*," another person writes in part:

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[15] "AI Pace Is Exhausting." www.reddit.com/r/cscareerquestionsEU/comments/1rdx3yb/ai_pace_is_exhausting 25 Feb 2026.

> *"Every other week they're handing out licenses to another emerging tool, toting how much more "productive" it will make us,* ***telling us that we'll fall behind the curve if we don't use them****."*
>
> [16]

These findings align with classic technostress mechanisms: techno-complexity (a rising learning burden) and techno-uncertainty (frequent change in tools and norms).[17] When tools and "best practices" evolve faster than training or job redesign, time-poor workers often experience AI learning as additional load rather than empowerment.

3. Pressure to work faster and raise performance standards (throughput intensity)

Pressure to work faster and raise performance standards because "the AI can do it in seconds." When the first draft arrives almost instantly, timelines compress and "fast turnaround" becomes the default expectation. In many settings, efficiency gains are absorbed into expanded scope and pace rather than reduced workload: "Can you turn that around today?" becomes "Can you turn that around in the next hour?" because AI produced a draft in 30 seconds. At the same time, the bar can shift from "a decent draft" to "a polished deliverable," as AI makes surface-level polish more accessible and raises perceived performance standards.

Some posters reported that their leaders expect that the time saved using AI tools can be reappropriated to doing more tasks or to handling many simultaneous projects, while the majority of people said that the tools need to be "babysat" and they need detail-focused revision making the time savings negligible.

> *"IMO [in my opinion] the feeling of exhaustion isn't coming from the newly arriving models and tools themselves.* ***It's the very obvious (unrealistic) expectations of our managers/employers*** *that with every new update of said tools,* ***we will be a factor more effective and productive****. This is why we feel constant pressure."*
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[16] "AI is draining my passion." www.reddit.com/r/devops/1ozd2i5/ai_is_draining_my_passion/ 17 Nov 2025.

[17] Tarafdar, M., Tu, Q., Ragu-Nathan, B. S., & Ragu-Nathan, T. S. (2007). The impact of technostress on role stress and productivity. *Journal of Management Information Systems*, *24*(1), 301–328. https://doi.org/10.2753/MIS0742-1222240109
Ragu-Nathan, T. S., Tarafdar, M., Ragu-Nathan, B. S., & Tu, Q. (2008). The consequences of technostress for end users in organizations: Conceptual development and empirical validation. *Information Systems Research*, *19*(4), 417–433. https://doi.org/10.1287/isre.1070.0165

> "*Its [AI] like a burst of productivity, but you need to sacrifice a lot of time context engineering, and thinking if your prompt is worth the tokens in burns.*"
> [18]

4. Social Isolation (network weakening)

As employees turn to AI for answers — and often trust AI more than colleagues — the result can be loneliness at work, weaker belonging, and fewer relational buffers against stress. Instead of asking a teammate for guidance (and receiving reassurance and connection alongside the answer), a worker who queries an AI tool gets information but no social support. Similarly, teams may share fewer half-formed ideas because AI can generate polished outputs, reducing opportunities for collaborative sensemaking. When AI takes over the informal "Can you help me think through this?" exchanges that build trust and psychological safety, something important is quietly lost.

On Reddit, one poster described the isolation of being the last human reviewer on a team whose work is now generated by LLMs:

> "*I'm the one human that has to review and leave real comments. I feel like I am just interfacing with robots all day and no one puts care into their work anymore. I really used to love writing and reviewing code. Now I feel like I'm just here to teach AI how to write better code, because my PR comments are probably just put directly into an LLM prompt.*"
> [10]

This pattern has measurable organisational consequences. Research shows that heavy AI users often feel less psychologically safe and connected at work. The 2025 Upwork survey found that the most frequent AI users were far more likely to report feeling disconnected from their team.[19] Burnout frameworks consistently identify social support — from peers, managers, and collaborators — as one of the most important resources buffering against exhaustion and cynicism. As AI silently replaces some of those interactions, employees lose a buffer they may not even notice until it is gone.

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[18] "do you feel tired faster after working with AI?" www.reddit.com/r/cursor/comments/1nbbii6/do_you_feel_tired_faster_after_working_with_ai/ 7 Sep 2025.

[19] Upwork Research Institute, "AI at Work: Navigating the Tension Between Promise and Peril," 2025, https://www.upwork.com/research/ai-at-work-2025.

5. Unnatural interfaces and interaction friction (prompt burden and workflow disruption)

Beyond social isolation, AI tools can create a distinct and under-recognised source of strain in the moment-to-moment experience of work: the friction of prompting itself. For many workers, using AI requires making the implicit explicit — translating years of tacit skill, intuition, and contextual knowledge into plain-text instructions that a language model can follow. This translation burden is cognitively demanding and, for experts in their field, can feel deeply unnatural.

Some workers find that the prompting process simply does not fit the grain of their work. It can be difficult to articulate what needs to change or what outcome is needed when the knowledge is embodied or procedural — something they would simply *do*, not describe. When that translation fails, and the AI returns something unhelpful, the corrective loop of re-prompting, re-evaluating, and re-steering adds fatigue on top of frustration. People on Reddit reported this as a recurring source of exhaustion:

> *"I spend all day everyday having 'do this, no this, not that way, like this' conversations with AI agents. It always starts so well and seems so promising...but takes hours of labor and ultimately ends with a decent amount of disappointment."* [20]

> *"But I just battled with an AI prompt for TWO hours because it would ignore the specifications I inputted over and over again. One time I came so close to getting it right, I changed a small paragraph to be more specific and suddenly the next output was a complete hallucination."* [13]

For workers whose craft involves intuitive, embodied skill — designers, writers, engineers — the experience can go deeper than frustration. The shift to prompt-driven work can disrupt the conditions that make work feel meaningful and generative:

> *"The creative process used to feel more natural, more instinctive. My eyes would catch what needed adjusting, my hands would just do it, and my gut would give me instant feedback if I was creating something dope or [messing] up. Understanding context, pulling an impossible blend of references subconsciously, juggling a dozen techniques in real time without even noticing it. Sometimes all of this would trigger a flow state and everything would be seamless, automatic.* [12]

[20] "I'm exhausted by AI because I just wasted 2 hours of my life over and over again." www.reddit.com/r/womenintech/comments/1r2bed3/im_exhausted_by_ai_because_i_just_wasted_2_hours/ 11 Feb 2026.

> *Prompt-based tools have shifted that entirely.* ***Now, every single instinct that would normally have been executed subconsciously has to be converted into plain text.*** *Instead of just adjusting something on the fly, I have to stop, conceptualize it in my mind, translate my internal creative language into coherent English, and hope the machine doesn't ignore the details that were important to me. … Prompt-driven tools transform creativity from a natural and an instinctive flow into a constant filtering and translation of ideas.* ***It feels heavy, constrained, and honestly even mundane. Leading to less and less moments of actual creativity and inspiration.***"
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This disruption of flow states and tacit working rhythms represents a genuine ergonomic cost of AI adoption — one that does not show up in time-tracking data but is experienced acutely by those who rely on intuition and craft as core to their professional identity.

6. High-level Management and Low-level Review and Revision (decision fatigue, skills expansion, and Altitude Sickness)

When AI automates or accelerates routine work, humans may be left with a disproportionate share of ambiguous, high-stakes, exception-handling tasks. These tasks demand sustained attention, judgment, and accountability, which over time can increase strain and mental fatigue. A worker might spend less time drafting and more time evaluating, such as checking factual accuracy, risk, compliance, and stakeholder implications. As "easy wins" disappear, the cadence of small accomplishments that supports motivation and recovery can erode.

On Reddit, some people felt that they had to do more high-level planning and anticipation of results with AI, and they compared these feelings to managing an employee – and important explanation for the increase in cognitive load. Others compared it to training an intern or new hire, and made recommendations about how to provide context to AI so that it could function more independently.

> *"I've noticed something while working with AI: I'm getting mentally drained much faster than before. To give some context,* ***I used to only feel this way when managing teams****. On those days, I'd spend three or four hours arranging tasks, writing cards, and explaining what each person should do and by the end, I'd be completely exhausted. My brain just couldn't function anymore.*
>
> *Now, when working with AI, I get the same feeling. I can't pinpoint the exact reason, but I suspect it comes from the type of thinking involved. It's not just problem-solving; it's high-level thinking. You're looking at the full picture, anticipating future outcomes, considering how instructions could be interpreted (or misinterpreted), and juggling multiple perspectives all at once.* ***Writing a task for AI feels almost like writing a task for a human employee, you need to be precise if you want the right result****."*
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Interestingly, these high-level tasks are now coupled with very low-level tasks to review, revise, and iterate on the output. When work is done manually without AI, there is often a lot of time spent dedicated to planning and then more time dedicated to synthesizing the results in a way that conveys the desired message. Then, decisions occur within the generation process – working for some time and then making a decision and then more working and so on. In contrast, with AI, when the synthesis work is offloaded, people spend more time making decisions about whether to use the AI content, try to generate more or different content, determine how to change a prompt to revise the content, and many other detailed decisions. Without the actual work between the decisions, the imbalance can be fatiguing.

> *"My time tracking says I'm saving roughly 8 hours a week. But I'm more tired than before. Which should make no sense. At first I thought I was just using the tools wrong. Then I started paying attention to where the exhaustion actually comes from.* ***Every AI output is a judgment call****. Is this response good enough and aligned with my target? Do I regenerate? How deep do I verify? I'm making these micro-decisions 50+ times a day and honestly, it's exhausting. … None of this shows up in time tracking (which is a related problem) but it definitely shows up in how I feel at the end of my day."*

[21]

Others commented that the decision-making part of the process is what keeps a human relevant in the work. New agentic workflows may remove more of the decision-making, but at the potential cost of more job loss or replaceability which may cause additional anxiety.

> *"AI can make you faster, but only if you stay in the driver's seat. As tools move closer to orchestration and start making sequencing and decision-level choices, the risk is letting them think for you rather than with you.* ***That's where speed turns into replaceability, because you've handed over the part of the job that actually carries value****."*

[8]

7. Longer hours and blurred boundaries between work and personal time (workload creep)

[21] "Anyone else exhausted despite AI 'saving time'? www.reddit.com/r/ProductManagement/comments/1oo7h05/anyone_else_exhausted_despite_ai_saving_time/ 4 Nov 2025.

Pandemic-era digital trace analyses already showed that remote and hybrid work lengthened the workday and increased after-hours communication.[22] Early research suggests generative AI may further amplify this pattern by reducing the friction to starting "just one more" task. Late-night emails or weekend Slack messages may become more common as AI makes it easier to produce quick drafts. There is the potential this may encourage more tasks, more iterations, and fewer natural stopping points. In an 8-month field study, researchers observed that AI adoption often coincided with faster pace, broader task scope, and work extending into more hours of the day, even without mandates—creating "workload creep."[23]

Reddit users have commented that accompanied by spiraling pressure to work faster, there is also a tendency of the work day getting longer and the actual workload increasing:

> *"Today, I'm completely burned out because I'm working 12-15 hours every day.* ***My work has increased by at least 5x. Whenever I push back citing lack of bandwidth (happened twice), i am told how it should be manageable since we have AI.*** *When i ask for additional resources, they say why do we need another hire when we have AI. Whenever I ask them for a little more time, i get the same reply."*

[24]

> *"****It's kind of ironic that AI, meant to make our lives easier, seems to be pushing the needle on work hours instead of reducing them****. I've noticed the same trend, AI is speeding things up, but with that comes a higher demand to produce more. It's almost like we're trapped in a cycle where being more efficient just leads to more responsibility.*
>
> *I've seen this in my own work too. The faster you get things done with AI, the more people expect you to deliver and that can create a lot of pressure. You mentioned scope creep, which resonates a lot. It feels like the bar keeps rising, and the workload keeps expanding in response to those new AI driven capabilities."*

[25]

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[22] Harvard Business School Working Knowledge. (2020). You're right, you are working longer and attending more meetings. https://www.library.hbs.edu/working-knowledge/you-re-right-you-are-working-longer-and-attending-more-meetings; Atlassian. (2021). Data analysis: Has the length of the workday changed during COVID? Atlassian Blog. https://www.atlassian.com/blog/teamwork/data-analysis-length-of-workday-covid
Javier Hernandez, Vedant Das Swain, Jina Suh, Daniel McDuff, Judith Amores, Gonzalo Ramos, Kael Rowan, Brian Houck, Shamsi T. Iqbal, Mary Czerwinski: Triple Peak Day: Work Rhythms of Software Developers in Hybrid Work. IEEE Trans. Software Eng. 51(2): 344-354 (2025)

[23] Ranganathan, A., & Ye, X. M. (2026). AI doesn't reduce work — it intensifies it. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/2026/02/ai-doesnt-reduce-work-it-intensifies-it

[24] "AI has absolutely ruined my life." www.reddit.com/r/antiwork/comments/1rh20lc/ai_has_absolutely_ruined_my_life/ 28 Feb 2026.

[25] "Could AI increase our workhours instead of reducing it?" https://www.reddit.com/r/ArtificialInteligence/comments/1j5hjxu/could_ai_increase_our_workhours_instead_of/ 7 Mar 2025.

Burnout in other theoretical contexts

These stressors illustrate that AI-induced burnout is not a completely new type of burnout, but rather the latest evolution of the age-old overwork and stress problem, now amplified by technology. AI-related burnout maps closely onto established frameworks for understanding workplace strain and exhaustion.

Job Demands–Resources (JD-R) Model

According to the JD-R framework, any job combines "demands" (aspects of work that require effort and drain employees, such as long hours or high complexity) and "resources" (factors that support motivation or buffer stress, such as social support, autonomy, and training). Burnout occurs when demands chronically exceed resources. In this light, AI can simultaneously add job demands (such as increased cognitive load, faster pace, continual upskilling, and after-hours connectivity), while also creating new resources, such as time savings or decision support, that often do not rise in proportion to the added demands. [26]

One recent longitudinal study framed AI's effects in JD-R terms and found that AI adoption can function as both a resource and a demand at once: it may improve productivity yet also introduce technostress that increases exhaustion and work–family conflict.[27] This dual nature means that an organization's implementation choices—providing training, guidance, realistic workload adjustments, and protected time to learn—are crucial to preventing burnout.

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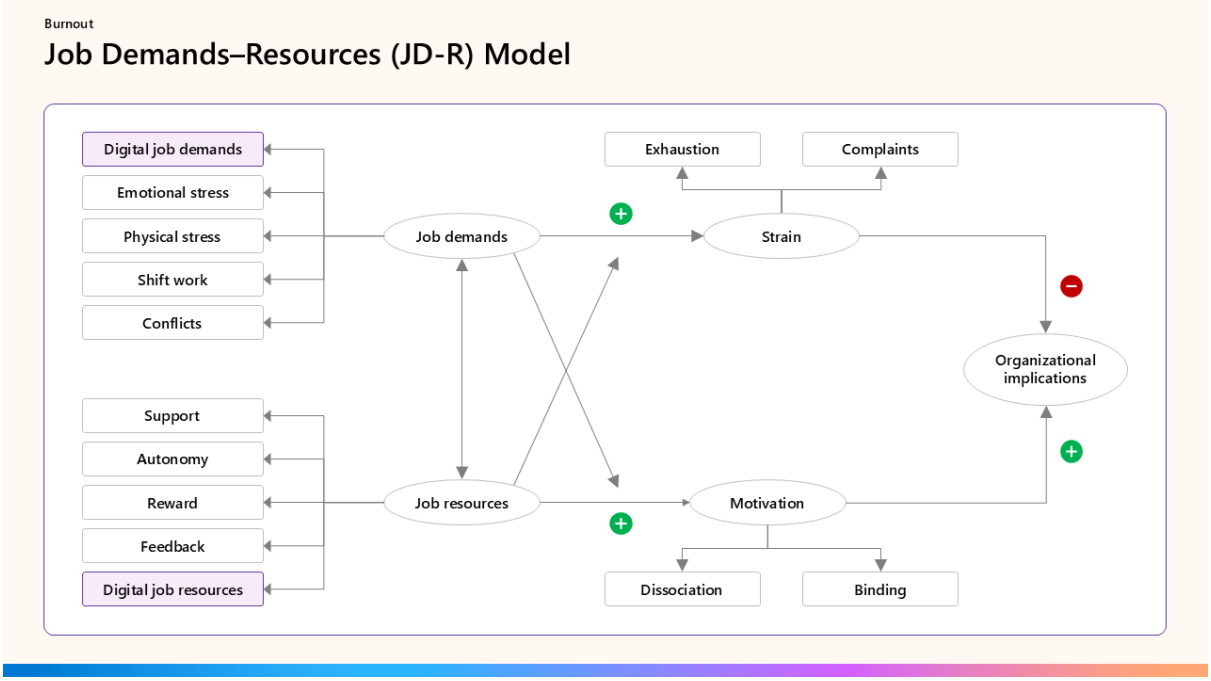
[26] Demerouti, E., Bakker, A. B., Nachreiner, F., & Schaufeli, W. B. (2001). The job demands-resources model of burnout. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 86(3), 499–512. https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.86.3.499

[27] Scholze, A., & Hecker, A. (2024). The job demands-resources model as a theoretical lens for the bright and dark side of digitization. *Computers in Human Behavior*, *155*, 108177. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2024.108177

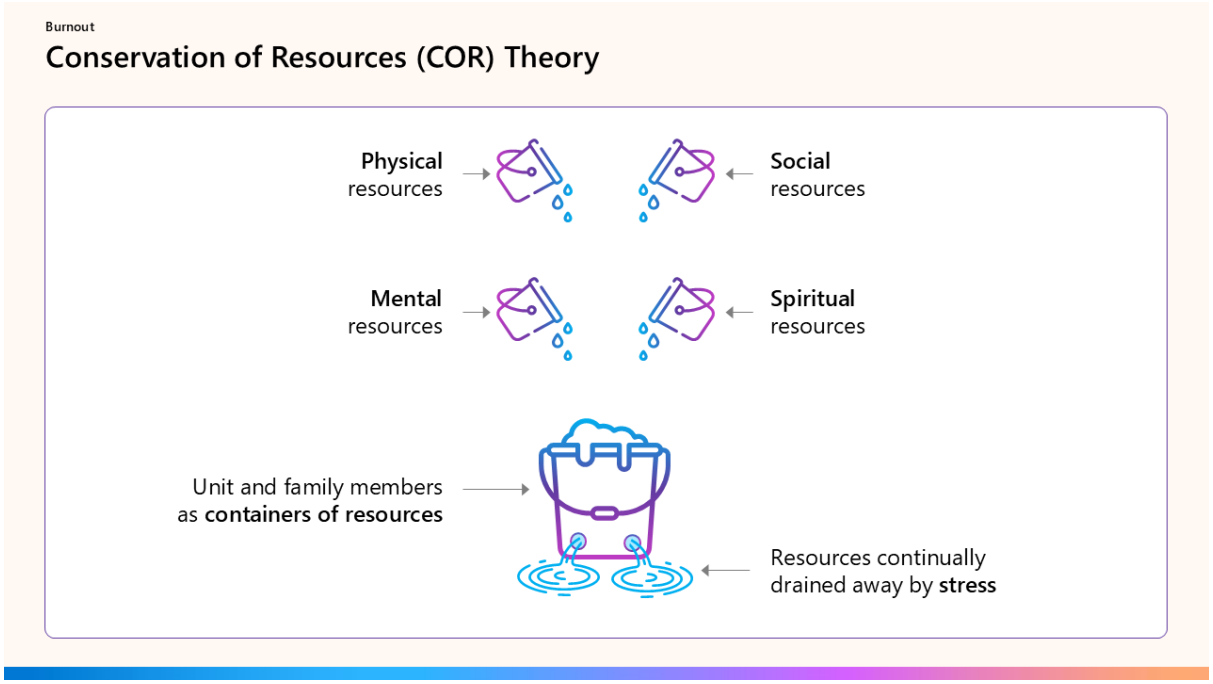


Conservation of Resources (COR) Theory

COR theory posits that people strive to preserve and build resources such as time, energy, skills, and social support, and that stress and burnout emerge when these resources are threatened or depleted. [28] From a COR perspective, AI-related burnout can be seen as a "resource loss spiral." An always-on assistant, for example, can erode time and cognitive energy: each after-hours alert or new tool to master draws on finite resources. Without sufficient recovery (through rest, support, autonomy, and clear boundaries), employees experience net loss, intensifying burnout over time.

Conversely, if AI genuinely frees up time or reduces menial tasks, it can represent a resource gain; yet in many settings, those gains are rapidly reinvested into additional work and higher expectations, leaving the overall balance unchanged or even worse. Guarding against net resource loss therefore requires ensuring that employees benefit from efficiency gains in the form of shorter days, sustainable workloads, and meaningful recovery.

[28] Hobfoll, S. E. (1989). Conservation of resources: A new attempt at conceptualizing stress. *American Psychologist*, 44(3), 513–524. https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.44.3.513



Evolving Nature of Burnout

Burnout is not one-size-fits-all. Maslach and Leiter's work shows that people can experience distinct burnout profiles.[29] Some individuals become "overextended" (primarily exhausted but still engaged with their work), while others become "disengaged" or feel ineffective (more cynical, withdrawn, or doubtful of their impact, even if not yet at extreme exhaustion). AI-related burnout can plausibly manifest in these different forms.

For example, an employee overwhelmed by AI-driven task overload may resemble the overextended profile: high exhaustion, but ongoing commitment to performance. An employee who feels alienated by automation - believing their role has become meaningless or stripped of human connection - may fit a more disengaged or ineffective profile, marked by cynicism and a diminished sense of efficacy.

Recognizing these nuances matters for intervention design: someone who is overextended may need workload relief and clearer boundaries, whereas a disengaged employee may need reconnection to purpose, re-skilling, or role redesign to restore meaning and a sense of contribution.

[29] Leiter, M. P., & Maslach, C. (2016). Latent burnout profiles: A new approach to understanding the burnout experience and its consequences. *Journal of Occupational Health Psychology*, 21(4), 489–498. https://doi.org/10.1037/ocp0000023

Why does it matter?

Burnout has long been known to hurt both employees and organizations, and AI-induced burnout is proving no different – perhaps even more insidious if ignored. There are several parts to why burnout is significant.

Employee Well-being & Mental Health

Burnout is officially recognized by the World Health Organization as an occupational phenomenon resulting from chronic workplace stress.[30] Burnout can manifest in serious health issues (chronic stress, anxiety, sleep disorders) and reduced quality of life for employees. By taking away "low-cognition" breaks and adding new pressures, AI might actually accelerate the path to burnout. In interviews, tech workers describe feeling like *"the AI doesn't get tired between problems – I do"*, highlighting the one-sided nature of human-machine collaboration. Prolonged exposure to such pressures without relief can lead to full-fledged burnout.

Productivity Paradox

While AI promises efficiency, burnout undercuts productivity in the long run. Burnt-out employees experience reduced cognitive capacity, more mistakes, and lower creativity. Microsoft's own Work Trend Index found that employees who feel exhausted are 3.5× more likely to struggle with creative and strategic thinking.[31] So if AI's benefits are paired with rising burnout, any immediate productivity boosts could be unsustainable. There's even early evidence that peak productivity from AI use can be short-lived: a Harvard Business Review study found initial excitement about AI time-savings gave way to "workload creep" – workers simply took on more tasks until they became overloaded and performance suffered.[32]

Retention and Talent Risk

Burnout is a leading driver of attrition. The more burned-out someone is, the more likely they are to disengage or leave. [33] This is especially true if employees feel the workplace is just piling on new tech demands without support. In a separate global study, one-third of workers said they are considering leaving their jobs because of

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[30] World Health Organization (2019). *Burn-out in the ICD-11*. https://www.who.int/news/item/28-05-2019-burn-out-an-occupational-phenomenon-international-classification-of-diseases

[31] Microsoft, "Work Trend Index: Will AI fix work? (Special report)," September 2023, https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/will-ai-fix-work

[32] Ranganathan, A., & Ye, X. M. (2026). AI doesn't reduce work — it intensifies it. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/2026/02/ai-doesnt-reduce-work-it-intensifies-it

[33] Schaufeli, W. B., & Bakker, A. B. (2004). Job demands, job resources, and their relationship with burnout and engagement: A multi-sample study. *Journal of Organizational Behavior*, 25(3), 293–315. https://doi.org/10.1002/job.248

increased stress from AI-driven work demands.[34] Replacing employees (not to mention lost institutional knowledge) is costly. Particularly in high-skill roles, the talent that is most adept with AI may also be the most at risk of burnout and turnover if their work-life becomes unsustainably intense, as their roles are more difficult to be replicated by AI and an increased proportion of their work require high cognitive load.

Equity and Inclusion

Burnout doesn't affect everyone equally. Foundational frameworks like the aforementioned JD-R model remind us that the impact of new demands depends on the resources people have. Not all employees have equal access to resources like training, support, or control over their schedules. If certain groups (e.g. those with less tech background, or those juggling more home responsibilities) experience AI adoption as a heavier *net* demand, they may be more vulnerable to burnout. Emerging research also suggests that burnout can be influenced by identity and environment. For instance, the *Intersectionality Burnout Inventory (IBI)* examines how factors like one's demographic identity and feeling of belonging at work can shape burnout risk. In the context of AI, this implies we should be mindful of whether some groups (say, non-technical roles or older workers) feel more stress from AI-related changes than others, and ensure inclusion in training and support efforts.

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2. How Can We Measure Strain from AI?

Measuring AI-related burnout requires a multi-faceted approach, combining *subjective data* (how employees feel) with *objective data* (how they work). Traditional burnout assessments – such as the **Maslach Burnout Inventory (MBI)** or modern survey tools like **Microsoft Viva Glint** – capture employees' self-reported feelings of exhaustion, cynicism, and stress. These can be complemented by **Microsoft Viva Insights behavioral metrics** that reveal work patterns associated with overload or disconnection. By linking the two, organizations can monitor for signs of AI-induced strain in real time and address issues proactively.

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[34] Upwork Research Institute, "Upwork Study Finds Employee Workloads Rising Despite Increased C-Suite Investment in Artificial Intelligence," July 23, 2024, https://finance.yahoo.com/news/upwork-study-finds-employee-workloads-130000327.html.

Employee Surveys (Glint & Burnout Scales)

To gauge burnout (or related states like stress and engagement), organizations often use anonymous surveys. Microsoft's **Viva Glint** platform, for example, can pulse employees with questions and statements (e.g."*I am able to successfully balance my work and personal life*") to track sentiment. It's critical to use validated, multi-dimensional measures – as Maslach & Leiter (2021) caution,[35] burnout is complex and cannot be captured by a single question. Common practice is to measure factors like exhaustion, job satisfaction, work–life balance, etc., separately. By correlating these survey results with AI usage patterns, one can test, for instance, if teams using Copilot or other AI tools heavily are reporting higher stress or lower engagement. A 2024 study did exactly this: it found that AI adoption heightened job stress, which then led to more burnout – but crucially, this happened primarily for employees with low self-efficacy in learning new tech. [36] In other words, if people feel unprepared to handle the new AI tools, their stress (and eventual burnout risk) skyrockets. This underscores the importance of measuring not just outcomes like burnout, but also employees' feelings about the change (e.g., *"I feel confident in my ability to use new AI tools"*).

Below is an example survey pulse to measure the current strains an employee is facing, along with their confidence in AI usage. The items are drawn from validated organizational survey scales and mapped to the key demand and resource dimensions of the JD-R model: workload and boundaries capture the demand side, while team support, recognition, and empowerment reflect the resource side. A single-item burnout measure (Dolan et al., 2014) is included as an accessible overall indicator, complementing the multi-dimensional items and providing a simple signal that can be trended across pulse cycles. Administered periodically and segmented by AI tool usage, this pulse can reveal whether heavier AI users are reporting more strain, fewer resources, or declining resilience over time.

Item Name	Purpose	Survey Item
Resilience	Employee's ability to cope with stress, strain, and burnout	I am able to cope effectively with work-related stress.
Happiness	Employee's overall satisfaction working at the company	I am happy working at my company.

[35] Maslach, C., & Leiter, M. P. (2021, March 19). How to measure burnout accurately and ethically. Harvard Business Review. https://hbsp.harvard.edu/product/H0643Q-PDF-ENG

[36] Kim, B., & Lee, J. (2024). The mental health implications of artificial intelligence adoption: The crucial role of self-efficacy. *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications*, *11*(1), 1–15. https://doi.org/10.1057/s41599-024-04018-w

Workload Management	Employee's sense that assigned workload is reasonable and not overwhelming	In general, I feel that my workload is manageable.
Work-Life Balance	Employee's sense of balance between work and personal life demands	I am able to successfully balance my work and personal life.
Boundaries	Employee's ability to mentally and emotionally disconnect from work during non-work time	I am able to disconnect from work during non-work time.
Team Support	Employee's assessment of support received from teammates and colleagues	I can get the help I need from my teammates and colleagues.
Teamwork	Employee's sense of cooperation and shared direction among team members	Where I work, we feel part of a team that works together.
Recognition	Employee's satisfaction with acknowledgement received for efforts and accomplishments	I feel satisfied with the recognition or praise I receive for my work.
Role Clarity	Employee's understanding of goals, behaviors, and performance expectations in their role	I clearly understand what is expected of me in my role.
Empowerment	Employee's sense of authority and autonomy in decision-making	I feel empowered to make decisions regarding my work.
AI Confidence	Employee's level of confidence in their use of new AI tools	I feel confident in my ability to use new AI tools.
Burnout (Dolan et al., 2014)	Single-item self-rated burnout measure on a 5-point scale	Overall, based on your definition of burnout, how would you rate your level of burnout? 1 = No symptoms; 2 = Occasional stress, not burned out; 3 = Definitely burning out; 4 = Symptoms persistent and frequent; 5 = Completely burned out, may need help.

Table 1: Strain and Burnout Survey Pulse

Viva Insights

Microsoft Viva Insights provides a rich array of metrics that, while originally intended to gauge productivity and collaboration patterns, double as early warning indicators of potential burnout. Here are some key metrics and how they relate to the AI burnout mechanisms and classic burnout theories:

AI-Related Burnout Mechanism	**Viva Insights Metrics to Monitor (examples)**	**Related Burnout + Strain Constructs & Theories**
Longer hours and blurred boundaries	After-hours collaboration hours (total time spent working outside	**Job Demands**

between work and personal time *(workload creep)*	normal working hours); Weekend collaboration hours (time spent in work activities on weekends); Urgent email/meeting hours (time spent in urgent communications).	Increased workload and overtime are classic job demands in JD-R theory, leading to exhaustion. **Conservation of Resources** Working longer damages recovery time, causing resource loss (energy, personal/family time) and accelerating burnout.
Fragmented focus and information overload *(task switching and multitasking intensity)*	Uninterrupted hours (total long focus blocks without any digital interruption); Multitasking hours (time spent emailing or chatting during meetings); Interrupted hours (time that could be focused but got broken up by messaging or calls); Conflicting meeting hours (overlapping meetings).	**Job Demands** High cognitive load, multitasking and information overload are psychologically demanding, contributing to mental fatigue (exhaustion). They can also create a feeling of inefficacy as people struggle to make progress on meaningful work. **Technostress** This reflects techno-overload and techno-interruption, which correlate with strain and burnout.
Pressure to continuously learn new AI tools & workflows *(Learning time and technostress)*	Learning hours (time blocked for training/upskilling; e.g. Calendared learning time tracks hours scheduled for learning activities). Also consider Available-to-focus hours – if employees have no "free" work hours due to constant meetings + learning, they are likely stretched thin.	**Job Demands** This is a form of cognitive demand and role overload – similar to what the JD-R model identifies as work pressure leading to exhaustion. **Technostress** The techno-complexity of mastering new systems is a documented stressor that contributes to burnout in digital transformations. **Personal Resources** Employees with greater self-efficacy (confidence in learning new tech) handle

		this better – highlighting the need for training support.
Pressure to work faster and raise performance standards *(Throughput Intensity)*	Urgent meetings & emails (hours involving urgent requests); Time to close tasks (if measured; faster turnaround expectations may appear as shorter time between receiving and responding to communications, though not an explicit metric). Indirectly, watch Focus time booked vs. kept – a drop in kept focus hours could indicate people sacrificing planned focus or breaks to keep up with fast demands.	**Job Demands** The pace of work is itself a demand – the JD-R model and "intensification" research note that rushing and time pressure lead to stress and eventually exhaustion. **Cultural Expectations** As one study put it, when AI makes faster work possible, it can become "what's expected", creating a constant urgency to deliver and contributing to feelings of always being "behind".
Social isolation and weakened human connection *(Network weakening)*	Diverse ties (number of connections an employee has with people outside their usual group — fewer diverse ties signal siloing); Network size (number of colleagues interacted with regularly); Collaboration hours by team vs. solo (if available). These metrics indicate whether someone's collaboration network is shrinking.	**Job Resources** Social support from peers and managers is a key resource protecting against burnout in JD-R. If AI use leads to less interpersonal interaction, employees lose that buffer. **Research evidence** Surveys show heavy AI users often feel less psychologically safe and connected, with one report noting they had "lost a sense of team connection...fueling their burnout". Feelings of loneliness at work have been directly linked to worse health and engagement outcomes.
Unnatural interfaces and interaction friction *(Prompt burden and workflow disruption)*	This is harder to capture with standard behavioral metrics. Proxy signals include: • AI tool session length vs. task completion (long sessions with low output may indicate prompt friction);	**Technostress** Prompt friction reflects techno-complexity: the cognitive burden of learning to interact with systems that do not match natural working patterns.

	• self-reported frustration scores in pulse surveys; • Copilot assisted hours combined with re-prompt rates where available. • Qualitative signals — from focus groups or open survey responses — are especially important here.	**Flow disruption** Research on creative work shows that interruptions to intuitive, embodied workflows reduce intrinsic motivation and increase fatigue, even when objective output is maintained. This maps onto the efficacy and cynicism dimensions of Maslach's framework.
Higher cognitive load from a greater share of complex tasks *(Altitude sickness and skills expansion)*	(Qualitative and custom metrics): This is harder to quantify directly with standard metrics. However, managers can look at task composition and workload changes. For example, track if Copilot usage (e.g. Copilot assisted hours) correlates with any changes in overall work hours or outcomes. If AI is taking over simple tasks, ensure that total work hours are not creeping up regardless. Also, employee feedback (via surveys or focus groups) can reveal if work feels more tiring or less rewarding post-AI.	**Effort–Reward Imbalance** If AI reduces the "easy" tasks and leaves only high-effort work, employees might feel they get fewer moments of relief or accomplishment, risking exhaustion. **Motivation & Meaning** Empirical studies found that while AI assistance improved output, it reduced employees' sense of meaning and intrinsic motivation. Over time, this can feed into the cynicism and inefficacy dimensions of burnout (e.g., "Why do I feel so drained and unfulfilled even though I'm more productive?").

Table 2: Key AI-Related Burnout Mechanisms, Corresponding Metrics, and Links to Theory

As shown in the table above, we can map specific Viva Insights metrics to each burnout mechanism. By monitoring these, organizations gain concrete signals of potential concern.

After-hours work

After hours work, a clear sign of boundary blurring and overwork which is likely to drive exhaustion. Viva Insights' *After-hours collaboration hours* and *Weekend collaboration* metrics capture this directly. *Rising after-hours activity despite AI "efficiencies" should raise a red flag.* In fact, excess after-hours work is so predictive of

burnout that the latest *Job Demands–Resources 3.0* research explicitly calls out after-hours connectivity as a driver of psychological distress.[37]

Uninterrupted hours and Multitasking Hours

Focus fragmentation and multitasking – a decline in uninterrupted focus time or a spike in multitasking indicates that employees can't find sustained concentration – a pattern that correlates with stress and poorer productivity. Microsoft's research shows *68% of workers already complain of too little focus time*[38]. If generative AI tools generate even more "digital chatter" (notifications, drafts to review, etc.), these focus metrics could worsen, signaling increased cognitive strain. From a theoretical lens, fragmented attention contributes to the mental exhaustion component of burnout and can make people feel less effective as they struggle to make progress in a ping-driven environment.

Learning Hours

Continuous learning demands or even just the count of new tools introduced in a period. These indicate whether employees are being given (or taking) time to learn. If AI-related training time is high, it could mean an ongoing cognitive load on employees; if it's zero, that might be worse – implying people are *not* being trained, yet still expected to use new tools (which would be a serious resource gap). In JD-R terms, the introduction of new AI systems is a job demand (akin to techno-complexity) that can cause stress unless balanced with the resource of sufficient training and support. Organizations should measure and ensure that employees have *scheduled learning time* and feel their AI learning needs are met, to avoid a scenario where constant change leads to frustration and burnout.

Urgent Email Hours, Urgent Meeting Hours

A culture where these metrics rise may indicate that everything is becoming "urgent" or immediate, often a side effect of an AI-fueled acceleration culture. If employees are regularly breaking their scheduled focus times to respond to emergencies or senior leaders pile on more projects "since AI will help," burnout is not far behind. Qualitative data can complement this: for instance, ethnographic research observed that after AI tools were implemented, employees felt *no one had the "luxury" to slow down or do deep thinking manually anymore*. In the long run, such relentless pace

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[37] Li, Y., Zhang, T., Dong, M., & Ren, Z. (2025). Evolving the job demands-resources framework to JD-R 3.0: The impact of after-hours connectivity and organizational support on employee psychological distress. *Journal of Vocational Behavior*. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jvb.2025.023X *(confirm exact DOI and journal name at: https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S000169182500023X)*

[38] Microsoft (2023). *2023 Work Trend Index Annual Report: Will AI Fix Work?* Microsoft WorkLab. https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/will-ai-fix-work

can breed both exhaustion and cynicism, as people feel they've become machines expected to operate at machine speed.

Diverse Ties, Internal Network Size, Network Metrics

Isolation and eroding social connections – detectable through *network metrics*. For instance, *Diverse ties* count how many connections an employee has outside their usual collaborators; a drop in diverse ties or network size over time may suggest that an employee's collaboration circle is shrinking. If an AI tool replaces some of the interactions employees used to have with, say, a helpdesk, a senior advisor, or peer colleagues, those lost interactions mean fewer opportunities for social learning and support. Burnout frameworks emphasize the buffering role of social support and manager support in preventing burnout; losing those buffers makes employees more vulnerable. Recent studies affirm that heavy AI users often feel lonely or unsupported.[39] In a 2025 Upwork survey, the most frequent AI users were far more likely to report feeling disconnected from their team and lacking a sense of psychological safety at work. Another study aptly titled *"AI Doesn't Reduce Work – It Intensifies It"* concluded that AI adoption pushed people into more isolated, siloed working patterns and emphasized the need for creating an "AI etiquette" to protect teamwork and avoid overload.[40]

The interaction friction dimension of this strain (i.e. the prompt burden and workflow disruption described in Strain 5) is more difficult to capture through standard behavioral metrics and is better detected through qualitative methods such as pulse surveys and focus groups.

Copilot Assisted Hours And Hours Worked

High-level cognitive load only – this is a trickier aspect to quantify, but it can be inferred by combining several indicators and qualitative insights. Managers should watch for signs that employees are losing the "easy" parts of their work without a commensurate reduction in overall workload. For example, Microsoft's new Copilot usage metrics such as *Copilot Assisted Hours* can be examined alongside total hours worked. If 20% of an employee's time is now "AI-assisted," but their total work hours haven't decreased (or have even increased), it suggests the AI might have simply enabled additional output rather than reducing strain. Surveys or interviews can reveal whether employees feel their work has become more mentally intense. If

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[39] Upwork Research Institute, "AI at Work: Navigating the Tension Between Promise and Peril," 2025, https://www.upwork.com/research/ai-at-work-2025.

[40] Ranganathan, A., & Ye, X. M. (2026). *AI Doesn't Reduce Work — It Intensifies It*. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/2026/02/ai-doesnt-reduce-work-it-intensifies-it

people report sentiments like *"I do less of the easy stuff, my whole day is high-stakes decision-making now,"* that could indicate this mechanism at play. Academic findings support these concerns: one experiment found that while AI ("ChatGPT") took over routine writing tasks and significantly cut down task time, it *also* shifted workers' roles toward reviewing and editing, effectively removing variety and leaving mostly complex tasks.[41] Another set of experiments in the same paper noted that this led to diminished intrinsic motivation and increased boredom when the AI was removed – in other words, work became *less satisfying* even though it was more advanced. Over time, that lack of fulfillment combined with sustained mental effort can translate into the emotional drain and cynicism central to burnout.

In summary, measuring AI-induced burnout means capturing both *traditional burnout symptoms* (via surveys and well-being metrics) and *work pattern signals* (via analytics). Critically, look for misalignments: If AI is truly helping, total work hours should stabilize or drop, focus time should increase, and stress indicators should not spike. If instead you see rising after-hours work, high interruptions, and worsening sentiment, it's a warning that AI's benefits are being blunted by burnout risks.

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3. What Can Organizations Do to Mitigate AI-Induced Burnout?

Preventing AI-related burnout is about balancing the scales – keeping the technology as a *resource* that empowers work, rather than a new *demand* that overloads people. Here are key organizational-level strategies, framed by classic burnout prevention principles and tailored to the AI era.

Rebalance Job Demands and Resources

The JD-R model emphasizes reducing excessive demands and boosting supportive resources. If AI increases output expectations, revise goals and workflows to prevent perpetual escalation. Avoid letting "AI speed" turn into an excuse for chronic overload. For example, if an AI assistant saves an employee 2 hours per day in drafting emails or code, don't immediately fill that time with 2 extra hours of new tasks. Use those gains to allow more recovery and creative time. Set guidelines that employees are not expected to respond to AI-accelerated communication

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[41] Wu, S., Liu, Y., Ruan, M., Chen, S., & Xie, X. Y. (2025). Human-generative AI collaboration enhances task performance but undermines human's intrinsic motivation. *Scientific Reports, 15*(1), 15105. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-025-98385-2. Companion HBR article: Liu, Y., Wu, S., Ruan, M., Chen, S., & Xie, X. Y. (2025, May). Research: Gen AI makes people more productive — and less motivated. *Harvard Business Review.* https://hbr.org/2025/05/research-gen-ai-makes-people-more-productive-and-less-motivated

immediately at all hours. Microsoft's own experience suggests employees need at least 30% of their week for focused, strategic work (not meetings or reactive tasks) to be effective and engaged.[42] Ensure AI is helping achieve that – for instance by cutting down meetings – rather than inadvertently shrinking it.

Provide Resource Boosters

Accompany any AI rollout with ample training, support, and time to learn. This addresses the technostress of constant upskilling. One study found that employees with high "AI self-efficacy" – confidence in their ability to learn AI – managed AI-related changes without increased burnout, whereas those with low self-efficacy struggled significantly. Thus, investing in hands-on training, peer learning sessions, and helpdesk support for AI tools isn't a nice-to-have – it's a burnout mitigation strategy. Also, reinforce job control as a resource: give employees autonomy in how they use (or don't use) AI for their tasks, rather than imposing a one-size-fits-all mandate. When people feel they have a say in *when* and *how* to use AI, the technology becomes a resource (a way to make work easier) instead of a strict demand.

No-After-Hours Policy:

Strongly signal that employees are *not expected* to engage in work communications at night or on weekends (and turn off Copilot suggestions during those hours). Some companies implement periods of digital downtime, where emails and Teams messages are delayed to the next workday. This protects recovery time, aligning with Conservation of Resources theory: people need to replenish their energy, not face continuous resource drain.

Focus Time & Deep Work:

Use Viva Insights to schedule focus time for employees and respect it. Encourage "*quiet hours*" or meeting-free mornings/afternoons where possible. Perhaps designate certain times of day (or even an official "No-Meeting Day") for deep work. Leaders should model this behavior by not interrupting employees during these times. Such practices acknowledge that humans, unlike AI, need uninterrupted periods for creative, high-level thinking (and for respite from collaboration overload).

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[42] Reclaim AI. (2025). *Survey of over 10,000 Microsoft Office users: Desired vs actual focus time*. Reported in CFO.com: The corporate work week grows even longer. May 21, 2025. Retrieved from https://www.cfo.com/news/the-corporate-work-week-grows-even-longer-survey-microsoft-reclaim-ai-/748638/. Microsoft, "Work Trend Index: Will AI fix work? (Special report)," September 2023, https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/will-ai-fix-work

AI-Ethics and Etiquette Training:

Just as there are email etiquette norms, create guidelines for AI usage that promote well-being. For example, discourage sending AI-generated content to colleagues outside of work hours, and encourage transparency when content is AI-created (to prevent confusion or mistrust). Training managers and employees on "AI etiquette" can set expectations, such as not expecting immediate turnarounds just because a generative AI could produce a draft quickly. This idea of an "AI usage charter" has been proposed to avoid the trap where *"what AI makes possible becomes what's expected"*, which was identified as a driver of workload creep in an AI-enabled company.

Leverage AI to Reduce, Not Add, Work

Ensure that the introduction of AI is truly helping employees do less *tedious* work, not just do more work. This may require re-engineering processes. For instance, if an AI tool drafts reports in half the time, can you shorten the overall report or reduce their frequency? If a chatbot handles level-1 customer queries, can on-call rotations be eased? The idea is to consciously convert AI's efficiency gains into tangible workload reduction for employees. Without intentional action, organizations fall into the trap of "AI-driven intensification" – simply taking on more projects because AI made each project a bit faster.

Leaders should be wary of the subtle message that can creep in: *"We can do twice as much now, so let's raise targets."* As the HBR (2026) study noted, companies need to resist the reflex to continuously raise the bar, and instead use AI to redesign work for sustainability. For example, perhaps AI allows your customer support team to handle 50% more inquiries – instead of immediately demanding 50% more volume, you could use that efficiency to permit reps to spend more time per customer or have more breaks, improving service quality and employee well-being.

Promote Social Connection and Support

Burnout is more likely when people feel isolated or under-supported, so it's vital to bolster human connection in parallel with AI rollouts. Some ideas include:

- Team Touchpoints: Ensure teams still have regular check-ins, mentorship sessions, and informal interactions. If AI is handling tasks that involve what used to be team problem-solving (like an employee asking an AI instead of a coworker), create new forums for peer learning and sharing of AI tips. This converts a potentially isolating dynamic into a collective one – e.g., an "AI user

group" where employees discuss how they use tools, challenges they face, and learn from each other's experiences.

- Manager Awareness: Train managers to watch for signs of digital burnout in their reports. With Viva Insights, managers can get aggregated (privacy-protected) insights on their team's workload and collaboration patterns – for example, if after-hours work or meeting overload is creeping up. Coupling these insights with periodic one-on-one conversations about well-being will help managers catch issues early. Managers should also actively encourage time off and role-model balanced behavior (for instance, not praising employees for being online late, or explicitly saying "good job" for smart work *not* just fast work).
- Celebrate Human Value: Combat any employee fears of "being replaced" by consistently emphasizing the unique value of human skills. Recognize and reward *interpersonal* contributions (mentoring, teamwork, creative insight) that AI cannot provide. This boosts employees' sense of purpose and belonging, countering the cynicism or insecurity that can come with rapid tech change.

Measure and Track Employee Strain

Organizations should embed the survey items outlined above into an existing employee survey. This will establish consistent measurement of strain and burnout for employees to track change over time as leaders implement the other mitigation measures in this document.

Use AI to fight AI-related Burnout

Finally, consider turning the problem on its head: How can AI itself be used to improve well-being? Microsoft Viva, for example, uses AI to generate personalized recommendations for taking regular breaks, having focus time, and even scheduling "virtual commutes" to disconnect at day's end. AI could also help by monitoring signs of overload (perhaps via sentiment analysis of collaboration patterns or emails, with privacy controls) and gently alerting both the employee and their manager. Some organizations are exploring AI-driven chatbots for mental health check-ins or digital coaches[43]. While we must be cautious about how we implement such solutions (to

[43] Durden, E., Pirner, M. C., Rapoport, S. J., Williams, A., Robinson, A., & Forman-Hoffman, V. L. (2023). Changes in stress, burnout, and resilience associated with an 8-week intervention with relational agent "Woebot." *Internet Interventions*, *33*, 100637. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.invent.2023.100637
Chang, C. L., Sinha, C., Roy, M., & Wong, J. C. M. (2024). AI-led mental health support (Wysa) for health care workers during COVID-19: Service evaluation. *JMIR Formative Research*, *8*, e51858. https://doi.org/10.2196/51858

ensure they are seen as supportive, not invasive), these tools could become part of a holistic approach to maintaining wellness in an AI-enabled workplace.

Choosing the Right Term – "Burnout" vs. "Strain" vs. "Technostress"

The concept we're discussing has been labeled in various ways. **"Burnout"** is a strong term, traditionally reserved for a severe, prolonged condition of workplace depletion (characterized by the Maslach dimensions of exhaustion, cynicism, low efficacy). We use *"AI-induced burnout"* here because early evidence suggests the end-state **does** mirror true burnout (with serious consequences like impaired functioning and potential long-term health effects) rather than just short-term stress. For example, reports of extreme cases – *employees describing themselves as "burnt out" by the AI-fueled pace*, or leaders experiencing what's been dubbed a "silent crisis of AI anxiety" – indicate this goes beyond temporary fatigue. However, other terms are also useful: "technostress" (or specifically "AI technostress") is often used in academic literature to describe the stress responses to using new technologies. "Digital exhaustion" and "AI fatigue" are popular terms in media and industry commentary for the more immediate sense of being worn out by the onslaught of AI tools and information.

In practice, these phenomena exist on a spectrum. Not everyone experiencing AI-related strain is in full burnout – they may be in earlier stages of strain or fatigue. The Conservation of Resources theory reminds us that burnout often builds through incremental resource loss over time, moving from acute stress to chronic depletion. So, an employee may start by feeling "AI fatigue" (tired of constant changes and information load), which if unaddressed could progress to AI-induced burnout (the more severe state of sustained exhaustion and disengagement).

As a bottom-line, whatever we call it – *AI-induced burnout, technostress, digital burnout, or AI fatigue* – the core challenge for organizations is clear. We must be vigilant in recognizing how the rapid integration of AI can unintentionally strain and overload employees, and we must apply the lessons of decades of burnout research to this new context. By identifying the specific mechanisms (longer hours, fragmented focus, learning pressure, accelerated pace, social isolation, interface friction, and cognitive overload) and by using data-driven tools to monitor well-being, companies can take proactive steps to ensure AI truly works *for* their people, not the other way around. A balanced, human-centered approach to AI adoption will help fulfill the technology's promise – *boosting productivity and innovation* – without sacrificing the health and sustainability of the workforce in the process.

Conclusion: Designing AI Adoption for Sustainable Performance

AI-induced burnout is not a forecast: it is already present in the workforce. The six stressors described in this paper (fragmented focus, continuous learning pressure, accelerating performance expectations, weakened human connection, elevated cognitive load, and workload creep) are not hypothetical risks attached to some future wave of AI adoption. They are the lived experience of workers today, documented in longitudinal field research, clinical survey data, and the candid accounts of employees describing their daily reality on public forums. The Ranganathan and Ye (2026) field study at a 200-person technology company, the Upwork Research Institute's survey of 2,500 global workers, and Microsoft's own Work Trend Index data converge on a consistent finding: the workers who are deepest into AI adoption are also the most at risk of burnout, disengagement, and departure.

The core conceptual insight of this paper is simple but consequential: AI does not create burnout from scratch. Instead, it shifts the balance between job demands and resources. It lowers the effort required to generate drafts, analyses, and responses — and in doing so, it can unintentionally expand scope, compress timelines, and intensify cognitive demands, especially when organizational norms and guardrails fail to keep pace. Left unmanaged, the efficiency gains of AI are silently reinvested into more work, not less — a dynamic that transforms a potential resource into an additional demand.

Addressing this requires action at three levels. At the measurement level, organizations need to pair traditional burnout survey instruments — grounded in Maslach's validated framework — with the kind of behavioral signals that platforms such as Microsoft Viva Insights can provide in near real time. Detecting strain before it crystallizes into burnout is the difference between proactive management and reactive crisis response. At the design level, organizations must resist the reflex to absorb AI's efficiency gains into expanded task scope. Protecting focus time, enforcing after-hours boundaries, and treating AI-enabled time savings as workload reduction rather than capacity for more work are not soft perks — they are structural burnout prevention. At the cultural level, leaders must reinforce the message that human judgment, creativity, social connection, and expertise remain the irreplaceable

elements of high-quality work, and that AI is a tool to support those capacities, not a substitute for them.

The promise of AI-augmented work is genuine. When implementation is thoughtful, AI can remove drudgery, free up time for meaningful contribution, and extend human capability in ways that are both productive and energizing. But that promise is only realized when organizations treat AI adoption as a socio-technical design challenge, i.e. one that demands as much attention to human wellbeing, role clarity, and sustainable pace as it does to capability deployment. Organizations that get this balance right will not only avoid the burnout trap; they will unlock AI's deepest value: a workforce that is both more capable and more human.

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